

Technology and Translation

Aletta G. Dorst uses Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale* as a case study on the abilities and limitations of Neural Machine Translation (NMT), comparing its work to students'. Specifically, she challenges assumptions, demonstrating that creative, literary, original metaphors are more easily processed by machines than simple metaphors since the former are expressed "as a simile... well-suited to direct translation" (Dorst, p. 178).

When considering how AI works, with a reliance on statistics, we can see the focus is on finding the most common translation of a word. We can easily see this in Dorst's discussion around how "touch" is used. As expected of a statistical engine, the translation is as a sense (Dorst, p. 181), the most common use of the word. Effectively, a missing aspect of the machine translation is the limitation in understanding how "larger stylistic patterns" (Dorst, p.184) overarch the way individual words and sentences are used.

As technology advances, we must consider natural language processing in the form of Large Language Models (LLMs). These draw from progressively more massive databases and also access casual language, such as Reddit and Amazon reviews, but retain the lack of an overall context with their emphasis of finding the most common use rather than the most contextually relevant use, especially when built as general engines rather than focusing on specialized literary tasks.

Similar to the warnings about making texts too easy to read in the target language and losing the original voice of the authors as Friedrich Schleiermacher emphasized, Jeremy Klemin notes that translators with AI in the post-editing method just pick the best of some options where choices are being made by the engine (Klemin, p. 2). Furthermore, examples like college essays losing as much variety and people in academic settings describing student writing as better but emptier and shallower tie to this. Klemin and Dorst both argue that AI makes literature more standard.

Overall, although larger databases allow AI to make fluent writing, increasing use of AI removes the power from human translators. It limits their hand in the process, making translations that don't capture all of the facets of literature "voice, rhythm, style" that "separate a functional translation from a great one" (Klemin, p. 3).